Lesson 21: The Writing Process: Prewriting and Drafting

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 3: Paragraphs, Essays and Cohesion

Adapted from College ESL Writers: Applied Grammar and Composing Strategies for Success by Barbara Hall and Elizabeth Wallace, Georgia State University - Perimeter College (CC BY-NC-SA): 4.1: The Writing Process - Prewriting and Drafting.

In this lesson

You will learn the five steps of the writing process and practise the prewriting strategies that help writers "conquer the blank page": using experience and observations, reading, freewriting, brainstorming and idea mapping. You will follow a student, Tuyet, as she narrows a broad topic, and then choose and narrow the topic of your own Unit 3 essay. Planning in this way saves time on every long assignment, including papers for your psychology course.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- List the five steps of the writing process in order.
- State the purpose and the audience of a piece of writing before you begin.
- Generate ideas with freewriting, brainstorming and idea mapping.
- Narrow a general topic to a specific one.
- Test a narrowed topic with the book's topic checklist.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
writing process	the steps a writer follows from first idea to final text	prewriting, outlining, drafting, revising, editing
prewriting	the stage in which you turn abstract thoughts into concrete ideas on paper or on screen	Prewriting strategies help you choose a topic.
rough draft	the first complete version of a text	Write a rough draft from your outline.
revise / edit	improve the content and organization / correct grammar, spelling and punctuation	the last two steps of the writing process
freewriting	writing without stopping about a topic for a set time, usually three to five minutes	Try not to worry about grammar, spelling, or punctuation.
jot down	write quickly and briefly	You may jot down any thoughts that come to your mind.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
brainstorming	making a list of more specific ideas under a general topic	Tuyet's brainstorming list
idea mapping (clustering)	showing ideas and their connections with circles, lines and arrows	Tuyet's idea map
general topic	a broad subject	mass media
narrow the focus	break a topic into subtopics, or more specific points	mass media → radio → music piracy
subtopic	a more specific point inside a general topic	television and radio
intimidating / daunting	making you feel nervous or unsure that you can succeed	Beginning to write can be intimidating.

Rules and explanations

Writing is a process

A blank page frightens many writers, but writing, like cooking or riding a bike, is a process that gets easier with practice. Just as a meal needs a recipe, ingredients and tools, a good composition needs a plan, resources and enough time. The book's **five steps of the writing process**:

1. Prewriting
2. Outlining the structure of ideas
3. Writing a rough draft
4. Revising
5. Editing

Start by writing down **why** you are writing (to inform, to explain, or another purpose) and **for whom**. A good topic covers what the assignment is about and also fits its purpose and audience.

Strategies for choosing a general topic

- **Experience and observations:** something that interests you, from your own life or everyday observations; a news story can also inspire you. Take notes to discover what you have to say.
- **Reading:** a magazine cover or a novel can suggest a topic. After you choose a topic, critical reading develops it: when you judge an author's main idea and support, you also discover your own opinion.
- **Freewriting:** write freely for a set time (usually three to five minutes). Do not worry about grammar, spelling or punctuation, do not stop, and do not doubt your ideas. If you get stuck, copy the same word or phrase until a new thought comes. A personal connection to the topic makes writing easier, and freewriting may even lead you to a better topic.

Strategies can be combined: use your course studies to find a topic, then freewrite to explore it.

Strategies for narrowing the focus

- **Narrowing the focus:** break the topic into subtopics, then choose the ones that fit the assignment and appeal to you and your audience.
- **Brainstorming:** write the general topic at the top of a page and list more specific ideas under it. One item often leads to the next.
- **Idea mapping (clustering):** write the general topic in a circle in the centre of the page, write specific ideas around it, and connect them with lines or arrows. The shapes show connections you may not have noticed.

Tuyet's example

Tuyet, a communications major, chose the general topic **mass media**. Rereading her syllabus, she realized it was too broad for a three-page paper, and that her readers (other communications majors) may want to read about a particular issue in mass media. Her idea map:

- mass media → **television** → cable (high definition, digital recording) and DVDs (Blu-ray)
- mass media → **radio** → music → downloads versus CDs → **piracy**

She narrowed her focus to **music piracy**.

Note: Tuyet's freewriting and her brainstorming list are pictures in the book, so they may not appear in your printed material; her idea map is described in words. The section also mentions "asking questions" as a prewriting technique, but does not explain it.

The topic checklist

Before you keep a narrowed topic, answer these questions. If you answer "no" to any of them, adjust the topic or choose another one and try the prewriting strategies again.

- Am I interested in this topic? Would my audience be interested?
- Do I have prior knowledge or experience with this topic? If so, would I be comfortable exploring it and sharing my experiences?
- Do I want to learn more about this topic?
- Is this topic specific? Does it fit the length of the assignment?

Practice

Exercise 1. Tuyet's process. Answer from the lesson material.

1. What were Tuyet's general topic and her major?
2. Give two reasons why Tuyet decided that her general topic was too broad.
3. In her idea map, which two subtopics branch from the general topic?
4. Which chain of ideas in the map leads to her narrowed topic, and what is that topic?
5. Put the five steps of the writing process in order: editing, outlining, prewriting, revising, writing a rough draft.

Exercise 2. Purpose and audience. For the essay you will build in this unit, complete: *My purpose: _____. My audience: _____.*

Exercise 3. Freewriting. Freewrite about one event you have recently experienced. Write without stopping for five minutes. Then read what you wrote. Does anything stand out as a good general topic?

Exercise 4. Brainstorming and idea mapping. Choose a general topic for your Unit 3 essay. Brainstorm a list of at least ten more specific ideas. Then draw an idea map with the general topic in the centre and at least two levels of subtopics.

Exercise 5. The topic checklist. Choose a narrowed topic from your map and answer the checklist questions. If you can answer "yes" to all of them, write: *My narrowed topic: _____.*

Speak with your tutor

- "I will freewrite in the chat for five minutes about [topic] without stopping or correcting. Then help me find two possible essay topics in what I wrote."
- "Let's brainstorm together about [general topic]: I give one specific idea, then you give one, for ten turns. Then help me group the list into an idea map."
- "Here is my narrowed topic: [paste]. Ask me the topic checklist questions one at a time, and tell me if the topic is specific enough for a short essay of about three pages."
- "Check my answers to Exercise 1."

Read aloud

Pause briefly at each |.

1. Writing is a process | that requires following steps and using strategies | to accomplish your goals.
2. Effective writing can be simply described | as good ideas that are expressed well | and arranged in the proper order.
3. Narrowing the focus means breaking up the topic into subtopics, | or more specific points.
4. A good topic interests the writer, | appeals to the audience, | and fits the purpose of the assignment.
5. Freewriting may even lead you to discover another topic | that excites you even more.
6. Word stress: BRAIN·storm·ing, PROC·ess, AU·di·ence, ob·ser·VA·tion.

Writing task

Your Unit 3 essay: prewriting and topic proposal. Use the strategies in this lesson to choose and narrow the topic of the essay you will develop in Lessons 22 and 23 (thesis and outline). Topic choices:

- a psychology topic: stereotype threat and how schools can reduce it (the reading in Lesson 20); stress and coping in university students; sleep and memory (PSYC 110, Lectures 7, 8 and 17);
- a topic from the book: working part-time while attending college, or taking on-line classes;

- the topic of your Lesson 18 or 19 paragraph.

Do Exercises 2 to 5 for your topic. Then write a **topic proposal** of 150 to 200 words in one paragraph: state your narrowed topic, your purpose and your audience; explain why the topic interests you and your readers; say what you already know about it and what you need to find out. For psychology sources, start with the free OpenStax textbook *Psychology 2e*, Google Scholar and PubMed Central.

Self-editing checklist

- My proposal names one narrowed topic, not a general one.
- I stated my purpose and my audience.
- I answered every question of the topic checklist with "yes", or I adjusted the topic.
- The topic fits a short essay (about three pages).
- My proposal begins with a clear topic sentence and ends with a concluding sentence.
- I used my own ideas from freewriting, brainstorming and mapping.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1

1. Mass media; communications.
2. It was too broad for her class's short paper requirement (three pages are not enough to cover all the concerns in mass media), and her readers, other communications majors, may want a paper about a particular issue.
3. Television and radio.
4. Radio → music → downloads versus CDs → piracy. Her narrowed topic is music piracy.
5. Prewriting, outlining, writing a rough draft, revising, editing.

Exercise 2 (example answer) My purpose: to explain how stress affects university students' exam performance and to recommend ways of coping. My audience: first-year university students who have not studied psychology.

Exercise 3 (example answer) A five-minute freewrite about the week before a psychology exam keeps returning to sleepless nights, forgetting what was studied and a friend who used breathing exercises. A possible general topic: stress and students' exam performance.

Exercise 4 (example answer)

- Brainstorming list under *stress*: exam stress; money worries; homesickness; stress and sleep; stress and memory; stress and physical health; breathing exercises; physical exercise; support from friends; time management; stress in first-year students; stress and social media.
- Idea map: *stress* in the centre, branching to **causes** (exams, money, homesickness), **effects** (poor sleep, weaker memory, illness) and **coping** (breathing exercises, physical exercise, social support). From *effects*, an arrow to *poor sleep → weaker memory → lower exam results*.

Exercise 5 (example answer) Yes to all the questions: I am interested; first-year students would be interested; I have experience of exam stress and am comfortable sharing it; I want to learn more; the topic is specific enough for a short essay. My narrowed topic: how exam stress affects first-year students' sleep and memory, and how they can cope.

My notes